Aravamudan, who was called Dan by his colleagues, explained that the idea was to launch sounding rockets.

‘Just sending up rockets, is it?’ I said.

‘Maybe a bit of research and development too,’ he said.

I was impressed, but the job wasn’t mine yet.

The interview panel comprised TERLS chairman Murthy, Kalam, D Eswar Das and M R Kurup. After the usual questions to test my knowledge on engineering, Kalam asked if I had done any project. I mentioned the axial flow compressor I had designed, fabricated and tested under the guidance of Prof Kothandaraman while in college.

‘You mean you did it all alone?’ said Kalam.

I nodded.

Kalam was impressed, and I knew I would get the job. But they did not tell me if I had cleared the interview. I waited outside, and when Murthy came out, I went up to him.

‘When can you join us?’ Murthy said.

‘Tomorrow.’

On 12 September 1966, nine days after a soiled newspaper from Ganapathiya Pillai’s grocery shop landed in my hand, I was offered a job with India’s first space science team for a monthly salary of Rs 650.